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CITY OF BERKELEY

BERKELEY CITY COUNCIL SPECIAL MEETING

FEBRUARY 25, 2025

>> MAYOR ISHII: I WOULD LIKE TO CALL TO ORDER THE SPECIAL MEETING OF THE BERKELEY CITY COUNCIL. IT'S TUESDAY, FEBRUARY 25, 2025. THANK YOU FOR BEING HERE. CAN YOU PLEASE TAKE ROLL?

>> COUNCILMEMBER KESARWANI IS ABSENT. TAPLIN.

>> T. TAPLIN: PRESENT.

>> THANK YOU. BARTLETT.

>> B. BARTLETT: PRESENT.

>> TREGUB.

>> I. TREGUB: PRESENT.

>> BLACKABY.

>> B. BLACKABY: HERE.

>> LUNAPARRA.

>> C. LUNAPARRA: HERE.

>> HUMBERT

>> M. HUMBERT: HERE.

>> MAYOR ISHII.

>> MAYOR ISHII: HERE. WE HAVE A SPECIAL WORK SESSION TODAY WITH THE BERKELEY ON THE BERKELEY ECONOMIC DASHBOARDS UPDATE. SO

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WE'RE EXCITED TO PASS IT OVER TO I THINK ELEANOR. THANK YOU SO MUCH.

>> THANK YOU. JUST GETTING OUR SCREEN SHARING GOING HERE. GOOD AFTERNOON, MAYOR, AND MEMBERS OF COUNCIL. IT'S GREAT TO BE WITH YOU ALL TODAY. I'LL ELEANOR HOLLANDER, THE MANAGER OF THE OFFICE OF ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT, WITH LIZ REDMAN, AND JENNIFER. WE'RE THRILLED TO SHARE THE ECONOMIC DASHBOARD. AS A COMPANION PUBLICATION, BOTH POSTED ON OUR WEBSITE AND IN YOUR PACT. WITH THAT, LET'S GET TO IT. MY FIRST SLIDE IS ABOUT EMPLOYMENT ACTIVITY. UNEMPLOYMENT IS UP SLIGHTLY IN BERKELEY. BUT IS HOLDING FAIRLY STEADY. JOBS IN THE EAST BAY GREW BY NINE TENTHS OF A PERCENT IN 2024. THE LARGEST ARE EDUCATIONAL, GOVERNMENT AND LEISURE AND HOSPITALITY GREW IN 2024. AND SMALLER -- YEAR OVER YEAR. THOSE THEY ARE SMALLER SLICE OF THE PIE AT 1.5% OF TOTAL JOBS IN THE EAST BAY. INFORMATION IN TRADE AND TRANSPORTATION IN UTILITIES SECTORS, EXPERIENCED DECREASES IN THE LAST YEAR.

>> MAYOR ISHII: I'M SORRY, ELEANOR, CAN YOU MOVE A LITTLE CLOSER TO THE MIC?

>> IS THAT BETTER? WE'RE SHARING. SPEAKING OF JOBS HERE ON THE LIST ON THE SCREEN ARE AT THE TOP 25 EMPLOYERS PRESENTED ALPHABETICALLY IN THE CITY OF BERKELEY. AS YOU KNOW, THIS IS REFLECTIVE OF BERKELEY'S DIVERSE ECONOMY. WE HAVE A HUGE NUMBER

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OF EDUCATION EMPLOYERS AND HEALTHCARE THAT ARE IN HIGHLIGHTS ON THE CHART. WE HAVE A PRIVATE LARGEST PRIVATE EMPLOYERS BAYER. SATELLITE AFFORDABLE HOUSING PAID THE TOP 25 LIST. I'M GOING TO TURN IT OVER TO TALK ABOUT OUR HOSPITALITY SECTOR.

>> THANK YOU, ELEANOR. GOOD AFTERNOON COUNCIL. I WANTED TO SHARE WITH YOU A COUPLE OF THE KEY SECTORS THAT DRIVE THE BERKELEY ECONOMY AND HOW THEY PERFORMED LAST YEAR. STARTING WITH HOSPITALITY SECTOR. VERY EXCITING THE CITY OF BERKELEY HOSPITALITY'S SECTOR FAIRED BETTER THAN NEIGHBORING CITIES IN TERMS OF OCCUPANCY RATES IN SAN FRANCISCO. I THINK THAT'S IN PART FOR A NUMBER OF REASONS THAT ARE SHOWN ON THE RIGHT. U.C. BERKELEY BECAME PART OF THE ATLANTIC COAST CONFERENCE WHICH DREW DOMESTIC VISITORS. WE HAVE A STRONG CULINARY SCENE HOPEFULLY YOU HAVE ENJOYED IT AND WILL CONTINUE TO. THAT CULMINATES WITH BERKELEY RESTAURANT WEEK. WE HAVE TERRIFIC PARTNERS THAT VISIT AND SHOWCASE A LOT OF THE INNOVATIVE AND SEEN AND LAST YEAR THEY DID FUNGI INSPIRED DISHES AT THE -- MARCH MUNCH CAMPUS MADNESS ON MARCH 21STTO 31STCOMING UP THIS YEAR. THEY ALSO HOSTED THE BIONEERS CONFERENCE FOR THE SECOND TIME IN BERKELEY, THAT DREW 1800 VISITORS TO THE DOWNTOWN THAT WILL BE BACK NEXT MONTH MARCH 27 TO 29. ALL THESE THINGS IN AGGREGATE ADDED UP TO 2.4 MILLION VISITTERS TO PAY AN AVERAGE OF $187.05 PER NIGHT. THAT CONTRIBUTED TO THE CITY'S TAX REVENUE IN TERMS OF THE TRANSIENT

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OCCUPANCY TAX OF $7.1 MILLION IN REVENUE. TURNING TO OUR STATEWIDE INNOVATION ECOSYSTEM. IT IS TRULY STATEWIDE ON THE MAP, IT SHOWS THE CONCENTRATIONS OF DIFFERENT INDUSTRY SECTORS DOING INNOVATIVE WORK. AND WHERE YOU CAN FIND THEM BY COUNCIL DISTRICT AND BY INDUSTRY IS THE COLOR-CODING HERE. SO THOSE BIG LARGE RED DOT SAID IN AND AROUND THE U.C. BERKELEY CAMPUS, OUR SOFTWARE COMPANIES. THE BLUE DOT WITH 37 ON IT SOUTH OF CAMPUS IN OUR OLD BERKELEY ART MUSEUM AND ARCHIVE, CONVERTED INTO THE LIFE SCIENCE INCUBATOR HAS A NUMBER OF INNOVATIVE BIOTECHNOLOGY COMPANIES. AND YOU ARE SEEING A LOT OF THE LIFE SCIENCE OR BIOTECH INNOVATION HAPPENING IN THE BLUE CLUSTERS OF DOTS IN WEST BERKELEY ALONGSIDE OTHER BIG DOTS, WHICH ARE HARDWARE COMPANIES DOING THINGS WITH QUANTUM COMMUTING OR RESEARCH AND DEVELOPMENT THAT REQUIRE A WORKSHOP OR LAB SPACE. THE WAY THE INNOVATION SECTOR IS COMPRISED THE LARGER CONCENTRATION ARE SOFTWARE, 35%. AND THEN, 32% IN BIOTECH AND HEALTHCARE. I DID WANT TO POINT OUT WE HAVE A GROWING SLICE THERE, THE ORANGE SLICE, 15%, WHICH IS IN CLIMATE TECH OR CLEAN TECH, COMPANIES MAKING ENVIRONMENTAL TECHNOLOGIES TO SAVE THE PLANET. THE TOTAL NUMBER OF THESE INNOVATION COMPANIES STATEWIDE IS OVER 400. AND I JUST WANT TO GIVE A SHOUT-OUT TO A MEMBER OF OUR TEAM, RACHEL, WHO HAS DONE A TREMENDOUS JOB. IT'S HARD TO KEEP TRACK OF START UPS. THE GREATEST SHARE OF THE 400 PLUS INNOVATION COMPANIES ARE

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EARLY STAGE. LIKE DEVELOPING A PROTOTYPE, THEY ARE FUNDRAISING VENTURE CAPITAL, COMING UP WITH A PROOF OF CONCEPT. SO WE'RE A CITY OF YOUNG, EARLY-STAGE INNOVATORS, LIKE COMPLEXES LIKE ELSEWHERE IN THE BAY AREA. THIS MAKES SENSE BOSS WE'RE RIGHT NEXT TO THE UNIVERSITY THAT IS NOW BEEN NAMED FOR TWO YEARS STRAIGHT AS NUMBER ONE IN THE WORLD FOR PRODUCING VENTURE BACK START UPS. THE CHART ON IT THE BOTTOM RIGHT, U.C. BERKELEY WAS RANKED NUMBER ONE FOR VENTURE BACK STARTED UPS AND FOR FOUNDERS AND FEMALE FOUNDERS, EXCITING TIMES IN BERKELEY. IN TERMS OF THE CAPITAL THAT THESE INNOVATION COMPANIES HELP BRING INTO OUR CITY, 2024 WAS A BIGGER BETTER YEAR FOR FUNDRAISING SINCE 2023 WAS QUITE TOUGH. AND WE DID HAVE MORE TOTAL FUNDS RAISED BY BERKELEY COMPANIES. THAT'S THE $1.2 BILLION, THAN THE YEAR PRIOR. BUT A SLIGHTLY FEWER NUMBER OF TOTAL COMPANIES THAT RAISED MONEY. AND IN FACT, WHILE IT SOME COMPANIES RAISED VERY LARGE AMOUNTS WHICH CONTRIBUTE TO THE 1.2 BILLION. MOST RAISED LESS THAN 20 MILLION. A FEW CONTRIBUTE TO THE LARGE NUMBER. SOME ARE SHOWN ON THE LEFT-HAND SIDE, THE TOP 10 DEALS. I CALL YOUR ATTENTION TO A FEW. COBALT METALS BROUGHT $537 MILLION. TO USE AI TO EXPLORE CRITICAL MINERALS USED FOR ELECTRIC VEHICLES AND OTHER RENEWABLE ENERGY TECHNOLOGIES. 12, WHICH IS A COMPANY IN WEST BERKELEY THAT SPLITS CARBON DIOXIDE, TURNS INTO AN INPUT TO OTHER PETROLEUM BASED PRODUCTS AND SUSTAINABLE FUEL WITH LOWER

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CARBON EMISSIONS RAISED $245 MILLION. A THIRD COMPANY, PERFECT DAY USING FERMENTATION TO REPLACE COWS MAKING PROTEINS AND OTHER COMPANIES IN THE CLIMATE TECH SPACE. THE VENTURE SEED CAPITAL, BUT THEN WE ALSO HAD THAT $14.3 MILLION NUMBER IN TERMS OF GOVERNMENT, RESEARCH, AND DEVELOPMENT GRANT GO UP YEAR OVER YEAR. WE'RE SEEING MONEY FROM STATE AND FEDERAL GRANTS. SIX COMPANIES WERE ACQUIRED. I HAD SAY OVERALL VERY STRONG YEAR FOR INNOVATION SECTOR PERFORMANCE. NOW TURNING THIS TO HOW THIS IMPACTS OUR COMMERCIAL REAL ESTATE AND VACANCY RATES. YOU ARE SEEING ON THE RIGHT-HAND SIDE OF THE SLIDE A NICE MAP THAT WAS PUT TOGETHER BY OUR PARTNERS AN THE BROKERAGE FIRM J.L.L. SHOWING WITH WHERE THE HUBS ARE OF LIFE SCIENCE ACTIVITY IN THE EAST BAY. AND THEY CALL OUT IN THEIR REPORT THAT BERKELEY IS THE BIRTHPLACE OF MOST OF THE EAST BAY'S LIFE SCIENCE OR BIOTECH START UPS. LAST YEAR THEY SAID BERKELEY HAD THE MOST COMPANIES THAT RAISED MANY OF ANY OF THE EAST BAY CITIES. AS THE MAP IS SHOWING, THEY DON'T ALL GROW HERE IN BERKELEY. SO THEY START HERE AT CAL OR AFFILIATED WITH THE BERKELEY LAB OR HEARD THAT BERKELEY WAS A PLACE TO BE. WHEN THEY LOOK FOR SPACE, THEY OFTEN FIND THAT THE SMALL GRADUATION SPACE THEY FIND OUT OF THE INCUBATOR ON CAMPUS FACILITY CAN BE FOUND LIKE OR PEERS IN ALAMEDA OR SAN LEANDRO. BECAUSE OF THE EXCITEMENT ABOUT LIFE SCIENCE WE HAVE SEEN A LOT OF INVESTMENT INTO THE WET LAB SPACE

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HERE IN RECENT YEARS. IT CREATED A LOT MORE SQUARE FOOTAGE OF R AND D SPACE. YOU ARE SEEING 48.6 BECAUSE WE HAVE THE BERKELEY FACILITY, WE HAVE FOUNDRY 31 AND WET LAB SPACES BUT THEY HAVE LARGER THAN THE SMALL COMPANIES NEED. SO WE HAVE QUITE A LOT OF VACANCY. IF YOU WERE TO DROP OUT THE BERKELEY COMMONS PART OF THE DENOMINATOR, THE 539 SQUARE FEET THAT IS WAITING TO BE LEASED YOU WOULD SEE OUR VACANCY RATE LOWER THAN YOU ARE SEEING IN OTHER WET LAB VACANCIES IN THE EAST BAY, CLOSER TO 20%. DOWNWARD PRESSURE ON THE PRICE PER SQUARE FOOT. LAST YEAR ABOUT 7 AND NOW IT'S JUST BELOW FOR RENTING THAT SPACE. TURNING NOW TO THE COMMERCIAL REAL ESTATE AND OFFICE SPACE. AGAIN, IT'S NOT THE MOST POSITIVE NEWS TO SHARE WITH YOU. WE'RE SEEING NUMBERS ACROSS THE ENTIRE MARKET GO UP IN TERMS OF VACANCY. OF OFFICE SPACE, THE NUMBER OF OFFICE USING JOBS IN THE EAST BAY HAS NOT RETURNED TO PRE-PANDEMIC LEVELS. ABOUT 10,000 FEWER OFFICE USING JOBS. VACANCY RATES ARE A LITTLE OVER 18% VERSUS 13% LAST YEAR. AND WE ARE LOWER THAN BERKELEY OR LOWER IN BERKELEY THAN EMERYVILLE OR OAKLAND. BUT STILL HIGHER THAN RICHMOND OR ALAMEDA. THERE IS ROOM FOR IMPROVEMENT THERE. OBVIOUSLY AGAIN WITH THE HIGH VACANCY IN OFFICE THAT PUTS DOWNWARD PRESSURE ON THE PRICES. IT'S A GOOD TIME TO BE AN OFFICE SEEKER IN A DOWNTOWN BERKELEY YOU CAN GET A PRICE OF A LITTLE OVER $3 PER SQUARE FOOT. A FEW YEARS AGO IT WAS CLOSER TO 4. WHO IS IN OUR

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DOWNTOWN TO VINCENT.

>> GOOD AFTERNOON. THANK YOU FOR HAVING US. WHAT I HAVE BEEN WORKING ON IN 2024 AND THIS IS A REPORT, IT SHOWS KIND OF THE COMMERCIAL OCCUPANCY THROUGHOUT THE CITY OF BERKELEY. AND IT'S BROKEN DOWN BY THE COMMERCIAL DISTRICTS. YOU WILL SEE IN THE CHART A FEATURE THAT TALKS ABOUT HOW MANY IN DOWNTOWN, ELMWOOD AND THROUGHOUT THE CITY. YOU WILL NOTICE THE CITY OF BERKELEY HAS A HIGH PERCENTAGE OF RETAIL. 31% OF THE GROUND FLOOR OCCUPANCY ARE THOSE PEOPLE WHO ARE OFFERING RETAIL SERVICES. THE SECOND IN THAT CATEGORY IS OFFICE OR OTHER NON-RETAIL USERS. THEN WHAT YOU WILL SEE IS IT FOOD AND BEVERAGE AS A PERCENT OF BERKELEY'S REVENUE IS STILL 13%. THAT CONCENTRATION TENDS TO GO UP AS YOU GET CLOSER TO THE UNIVERSITY. YOU HAVE LARGER NUMBERS OF STUDENTS AND VISITORS WHO WANT TO CONSUME THE FOOD AND BEVERAGES AVAILABLE THERE. NEXT SLIDE. THE OTHER THING WE'VE LOOKED AT THE COMMERCIAL VACANCY RATES. THIS YEAR WE ENLISTED THE HELP OF A COUPLE OF BUSINESSES FOR COMMERCIAL DISTRICTS. THEY HELPED US GATHER SOME OF THIS DATA. WHAT YOU WILL SEE OVERALL THE STATEWIDE AVERAGE DROPPED SLIGHTLY FROM 8.1 TO 7 POINT 5%. CERTAIN DISTRICTS WE SAW AN INCREASE IN THE VACANCY RATE. I'LL GO TO THE DECREASE IN VACANCY RATE FIRST. THE DECREASES WERE ALONG SAN PABLO AVENUE, ALONG SOLANO AVENUE, SOUTH BERKELEY, THE UNIVERSITY AREA, AND AS WELL AS IN THE

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STATEWIDE AVERAGE. THE FLIP SIDE, WE SAW INCREASES. THE LEVEL OF INCREASES CAN BE AFFECTED BY THE METHODOLOGY. AS AN EXAMPLE, IF WE LOOK AT DOWNTOWN WE MAY HAVE HAD A 50 SPACES AND ABOUT 240,000 SQUARE FEET WHICH CONSISTS OF GOVERNMENT OFFICES OR NON-RETAIL, WHICH COULD BOOST THE NUMBER OF 10.9%. THAT'S SOMETHING WE CONTINUE TO LOOK AT IS WHAT CAN WE DO TO MAKE SURE IT'S THE GREATEST NUMBER OF ACCURACY AND RELEVANCY. WHAT YOU SAW IN CERTAIN AREAS LIKE ELMWOOD, SMALL INCREASE. A SMALL INCREASE IN NORTH SHATTUCK. WE CAN SEE SPATS THAT TRANSITIONS DURING THE TIME OF COLLECTING THE DATA. YOU SAW INCREASES IN WEST BERKELEY, AND AMONG THE NEIGHBORHOOD COMMERCIAL DISTRICTS. THROUGHOUT THE CITY OF BERKELEY WE HAVE SMALL COMMERCIAL DISTRICTS, A BLOCK OR TWO, SUCH AS EUCLID WHERE THE IMPACT OF A SINGLE BUSINESS GOING UNDER HAS A BIGGER IMPACT THAN AN AREA OF DOWNTOWN WHERE YOU HAVE MANY OPTIONS AND PLAYERS IN THE MARKET. AND SO THAT'S REALLY WHAT I WANT TO PRESENT IN TERMS OF VACANCIES THROUGHOUT THE CITY OF BERKELEY.

>> THANKS, VINCENT. I WILL TAKE THE OTHER PART, WHICH IS THE CITY SALES TAX REVENUE. HOW THOSE SPACES GENERATE MONEY TO OUR CITY'S BOTTOM LINE. THE GOOD NEWS IS YEAR OVER YEAR IN 2024 CITY OF BERKELEY UP, SO THE ARROWS INDICATE THE YEAR OVER YEAR TRENDS. THIS IS THE BACKDROP OF THE SALES TAX DROPPING FOR THE STATE AND COUNTY. IF YOU LOOK AT IT GRAPH ON THE RIGHT, THIS IS

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THE SECOND QUARTER OF SALES TAX, APRIL TO JUNE. IN 2024, THE SECOND QUARTER WAS SLIGHTLY HIGHER THAN 2023. IT WAS NOWHERE NEAR THE AMOUNT IN 2022 WHEN PENT UP PANDEMIC SPENDING WAS AT ONE OF ITS HIGHER POINTS. IT'S HIGHER THAN THE MIDYEAR OF THE PANDEMIC IN 2020 AND 2021. WE'RE SHY OF THE PRE-PANDEMIC OF THE NUMBER. TALKING MORE ABOUT HOW OUR SALES TAX IS MADE UP IN THE CITY OF BERKELEY. THIS IS THE QUARTER 2 BY BUSINESS CATEGORY. THAT TOP LINE, WHICH IS GREEN, IS RETAIL. REPRESENTING 45% OF OVERALL SALES TAX. FOOD AND BEVERAGE IS 37%. PERSONAL SERVICES IS THE YELLOW LINE THAT YOU SEE DECREASING. THAT INCLUDES THINGS LIKE TRANSPORTATION SERVICES, FUEL PRICES AND GAS STATIONS. THAT EXPLAINS THE DRAMATIC DROP. TURNING NOW TO HOUSING AND INSTITUTIONAL BUILDING AND SORT OF PIPELINE ABOUT WHAT IS COMING. INSTITUTIONAL EDUCATIONS ARE DRIVING DEVELOPMENT. RIGHT NOW U.C. BERKELEY WILL BE THE LARGEST RATE PAYER IN OUR DOWNTOWN BERKELEY BUSINESS IMPROVEMENT DISTRICT. JUST TAKING A SORT OF SWING AROUND THE SLIDE IN CLOCKWISE ORDER, THE ANCHOR HOUSE OPENED, THE BAKER LABS WE TALKED ABOUT, VERY OCCUPIED AND BUSINESS. WE'VE GOT A COUPLE OF PROJECTS UNDER CONSTRUCTION, THERE IS THE GATE WAY CENTER ON HURST AND THE PROPOSED U.C. INNOVATION ZONE ON OX FORD. ON THE RIGHT-HAND CORNER ANOTHER EDUCATIONAL INSTITUTION. BERKELEY CITY COLLEGE UNDER CONSTRUCTION I'M SURE WE'RE FAMILIAR WITH. HOUSING DEVELOPMENT

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IN 2024 1,600 UNITS APPROVED IN 13 PROJECTS. AND THERE IS A COUPLE OF HIGHLIGHTS HERE, THE LAYER BUILDING OPENED ON SHATTUCK AVENUE. AND SUBMITTED FOR ENTITLEMENTS AND IF APPROVED JOIN EXTRA TALL BUILDINGS IN THE DOWNTOWN ALONG OUR MAJOR TRANSPORTATION CORRIDORS. LOOKING AT HOUSING COSTS, THE SALES MEDIAN SALES PRICE FOR A SINGLE FAMILY HOME IN THE CITY OF BERKELEY AS OF NOVEMBER 2024, $1.4 MILLION. SECOND ONLY TO PIEDMONT AT 2.9 AS A MEDIAN SALES PRICE FOR A SINGLE-FAMILY HOME. THOUGH THE PRICES INCREASED, THE VOLUME IS DOWN 12%. RENT SLIGHTLY INCREASED, THE RED LINE, THE DOTS. IF YOU WILL INDULGE US, WE WANT TO SPEND A FEW MINUTES TALKING ABOUT OFFICE ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT TO SUPPORT OUR DIVERSE ECONOMY IN THE CITY OF BERKELEY, STARTING WITH OUR LOAN FUNDS. IF YOU ARE AWARE WE HAVE TWO IN THE CITY OF BERKELEY. OUR LP WAS A LOAN PROGRAM SEEDED BY A C.A.R.E.S. ACT GRANT DURING THE PANDEMIC AND A REVOLVING FUND WITH SIX LOANS IN THE PORTFOLIO. WE'RE LOOKING FOR NEW OPPORTUNITIES TO LEND DOLLARS TO BERKELEY INSTITUTIONS AND BUSINESSES. IF YOU REFERRALS, WE'RE CERTAINLY WELCOME TO ENGAGE WITH THOSE CLIENTS.

>> AMONG THINGS WE DO IS WE PROVIDE SUPPORT TO THE COMMERCIAL DISTRICT THROUGHOUT THE CITY OF BERKELEY. WITHIN THE CITY OF BERKELEY WE HAVE DIFFERENT TYPES. WE HAVE THE FORMAL BIDS, WE HAVE COMMERCIAL DISTRICTS, AND WE HAVE ASSOCIATIONS. AND WHAT WE

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TRY TO DO WITH OUR WORK IS PROVIDE SUPPORT FOR EACH OF THOSE. ONE OF THE THINGS WE CAN CONVENE IS BERKELEY BUSINESS DISTRICT NETWORK MEETINGS, WHICH RACHEL COORDINATES FOR US. AND WITH THOSE MEETINGS WHAT IT ALLOWS US TO DO IS BRING DIFFERENT COMMERCIAL DISTRICT SAID TOGETHER SO THEY CAN TELL US THE PRIORITIES AND CHALLENGES AND HOW THE CITY OF BERKELEY CAN HELP THEM BETTER SERVE IN THEIR NEIGHBORHOODS AND ATTRACT PEOPLE. AND TO THAT POINT, ONE OF THE THINGS WE FOUND IS WE HAVE SOME COMMON THEMES WHICH ARE RUNNING THROUGH THE COMMERCIAL DISTRICT. ONE IS EACH OF THEM WANT TO BE ABLE TO ATTRACT MORE BUSINESSES AND ATTRACT MORE CUSTOMERS AND CREATE A UNIQUE IDENTITY, WHICH DRAWS PEOPLE TO THEIR COMMUNITY. A SECOND, IS THEY WANT TO PRIORITIZE WHAT THEY ARE GOING TO ASK OF YOU. THEY WANT TO BE ABLE TO COME TO THE TABLE WITH A SHORT LIST OF HIGH-VALUE PRIORITIES YOU CAN ACT UPON. THEY MENTIONED THOSE TO US. A THIRD IS THEY WANT TO CREATE SAFER, MORE ATTRACTIVE ENVIRONMENTS DEALING WITH THE UNHOUSED, DEALING WITH ISSUES LIKE TRASH, DEALING WITH ISSUES LIKE PARKING. SO THOSE ARE SOME OF THE ISSUES WHICH HAVE COME TO OUR TABLE WHICH WE'RE SHARING WITH YOU SO YOU CAN HAVE AN IDEA WHAT THE COMMERCIAL DISTRICT IN THE CITY OF BERKELEY ARE LOOKING FOR. AND PROBABLY THE THIRD THING WE HAVE A NUMBER OF LOOKING AT RENEWABLES OR STRATEGIC PLANS. THEY ARE LOOKING AT THE LONG TERM AND TRYING TO COME UP WITH PLANS FOR THE LONG TERM THAT YOU CAN

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SUPPORT AS COUNCILMEMBERS AND AS MAYOR. OKAY. THANK YOU.

>> THANKS, VINCENT. SPEAKING ABOUT MARKETING OUR DIFFERENT DISTRICTS WE CONTINUE TO RUN OUR HASHTAG DESERVED IN BERKELEY MARKETING CAMMING PAIN. IF -- CAMPAIGN, I HOPE YOU WILL FOLLOW US ON INSTAGRAM OR ANYTIME YOU ARE AT A COOL BERKELEY BUSINESS THAT INSPIRED YOU AND SEEMS ALIGNED WITH BERKELEY VALUES, USE THE HASHTAG, DISCOVERED IN BERKELEY. WE STARTED THE CAMPAIGN IN 2019, TO MAKE THEM FEEL PROUD -- THOSE INNOVATION SECTOR BUSINESSES I MENTIONED EARLIER ARE DISCOVERING HERE. AND SO 2024 WAS ANOTHER STRONG YEAR FOR THE CAMPAIGN. WE FEATURED COMPANIES ENABLING ADVENTURE TRAVEL, BELOVED BAKED GOODS LIKE SCONES AND BAGELS. ARTISANAL ICE CREAM COMPANIES. A COMPANY WITH AN INDUCTION STOVE AND OTHERS CURATING TEA CEREMONIES WITH TEA FROM ASIA, THEY HAVE LED TO 180,000 CONCRETE ENGAGEMENTS. SOMEBODY WHO LIKED THE POST, WHO READ THE ARTICLE, WHO SHARED IT WITH A FRIENDS, WHO DID SOMETHING TO REALLY ABSORB THE CONTENT THAT WE WERE PUTTING OUT THERE. AND YOU COULD SEE OTHER CAMPAIGN METRICS HERE OR INQUIRE LATER. I WANTED TO MENTION THE COPPER INDUCTION STOVE COMPANY WAS OUR MOST VIEWED ARTICLE OF OUR SLOT THIS YEAR. AND IT ALSO HAD THE MOST AD CLICKS AND THAT COMPANY THANKED US VERY MUCH FOR THE PROMOTION OF THE STOVES BECAUSE IT HELPED GENERATE SALES FOR THEM. BERKELEY SIDE, WHICH IS OUR KEY PARTNER IN PUTTING TOGETHER STORIES AND BANNER TOLD US FOLKS ARE

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GRAVITATING TO THE STORIES, THEY ARE THE MOST VIEWED. WE'RE EXCITING TO CONTINUE THAT CAMPAIGN AND ALWAYS WELCOME IDEAS FOR NEW CONTENT. WE CONTINUE TO SUPPORT BUSINESSES TO OPERATE IN A MORE ENVIRONMENTALLY RESPONSIBLE MANNER. WE PARTNER WITH THE ALAMEDA COUNTY GREEN BUSINESS PROGRAM UNDER THE BANNER OF THE BROADER STATEWIDE CALIFORNIA GREEN BUSINESS PROGRAM. AND THEY ARE THE ONES THAT PUT IN PLACE THE STANDARDS THAT A BUSINESS MUST ADHERE TO GET THE GREEN BUSINESS CERTIFICATION. THEY DO THINGS TO OPERATE WITH THE PLANET IN MIND. REDUCING WATER. REDUCING ENERGY CONSUMPTION. REDUCING THE SOLID WASTE THAT GOES TO LANDFILLS. WE CERTIFIED EIGHT NEW BUSINESSES AND 10 NEW CERTIFICATIONS LEADING TO 79 BUSINESSES TODAY THAT ARE GREEN BUSINESS CERTIFIED IN BERKELEY. AND 171 THAT HAVE EXPRESSED INTEREST IN THE PROGRAM. I SEE THIS IS A CALL FOR U.S. COUNCIL MEMBERS TO ENCOURAGE YOUR LOCAL BUSINESSES TO GET THAT GREEN BUSINESS CERTIFICATION OR IF THEY ARE ALREADY REGISTERED THE PROGRAM TO TAKE THOSE ADDITIONAL EXTRA STEPS TO GET THE RUBBER STAMP OF THE CERTIFICATION. WE ALSO CONTINUE A PARTNERSHIP WITH BERKELEY HIGH SCHOOL AND THE CAL STATE UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE FOR STEM EDUCATION UNDER THE BANNER OF THE BERKELEY START UP CLUSTERS, BERKELEY VENTURES, BERKELEY VALUES INITIATIVE, FOCUSED IN MAKING SURE OUR TECH COMPANIES GROW IN A WAY THAT BENEFITS THE ENTIRE COMMUNITY. WE STARTED DOING STEM TOURS WHERE WE TAKE

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BERKELEY HIGH SCHOOL KIDS OUT TO SEE ACTUAL COMPANIES THAT ARE INNOVATING AND HOW THEIR STEM SKILLS CAN BE APPLIED IN THE WORKPLACE. LAST YEAR WE ENABLED 125 STUDENT VISITS, THE NATIONAL SOCIETY OF BLACK VOLUNTEERS JUNIOR, AND HISPANIC ENGINEERS AND SCIENTIST CLUB AT CAL, BIOTECH ACADEMY ON SEVEN STEM TOURS. I WANT TO TAKE A MOMENT TO THANK THE COMPANIES THAT HOSTED LAST YEAR. INCLUDE A CORN TECHNOLOGY, STILL WATER SCIENCES, U.C. THEATER, TERRA BASED ENERGY, ARMORXAI. WE'RE LOOKING FOR HOSTED FOR 2025. WE DID TWO GREAT VISITS TO SKY DECK AND BAYER. IF YOU GO COMPANIES IN THE DISTRICT OR THAT YOU ARE CONNECTED TO IF YOU ARE LISTENING ONLINE OR IN THE CROWD, SEND THEM OUR WAY BECAUSE KIDS LOVE TO BE INSPIRED. SPEAKING OF THINGS WE DO TO SUPPORT EQUITY, WE'VE PARTNERED TREMENDOUSLY WITH THE BERKELEY CHAMBER OF COMMERCE OVER THE LAST YEAR TO MAKE SURE ALL OF OUR DIFFERENT ZONING RULES AND PROCESSES FOR GETTING A BUSINESS LICENSE AND WHAT IS IT TAKES TO GET PERMITS IS BETTER COMMUNICATED SO SOMEBODY CAN UNDERSTAND WHAT THE TAKES TO DO BUSINESS OR INVEST IN BERKELEY. ONE OF THE THINGS WE WORKED TO COMMUNICATE ON IS TWO MAJOR EFFORTS IN 2024. TO IMPROVE OUR LAND USE POLICY AND STREAMLINE FOR BERKELEY BUSINESSES. THAT WAS ONE CATEGORY OF UPDATED RULES SUPPORTING RESTAURANTS, BARS AND ENTERTAINMENT BUSINESSES. AND ANOTHER UNDER THE PACKAGE CALLED KEEP INNOVATION IN BERKELEY. WHICH MADE IT A LOT EASIER FOR RESEARCH AND

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DEVELOPMENT COMPANIES TO LOCATE NEAR CAMPUS AND A RANGE OF THE ACTIVITIES THEY CONDUCT TO TAKE PLACE IN BERKELEY. AND SO THEN BY DOING WEBSITES, WORKING THROUGH THE CHAMBER, E COMMUNICATIONS AND THEIR NEWSLETTER, ANYWAY WE COULD GET THE WORD OUT, WE TELL PEOPLE IT'S NOT HARD TO DO BEEN IN BERKELEY. YOU CAN GO TO THE DOING BUSINESS IN BERKELEY WEBPAGE AND DOWNLOAD MATERIALS OR LISTEN TO THE WEBINAR. WE CONTINUE WITH PROJECT EQUITY TO HELP BUSINESSES WITH SECESSION PLANNING AND TRANSITION TO BE WORKER OWNED. AND THEN, LAST BUT NOT LEAST TURN IT OVER TO JENN TO TELL US ABOUT ARTS AND CULTURE.

>> THANK YOU, LIZ. GOOD AFTERNOON. IN ADDITION TO BUSINESS SERVICES, OFFICE OF ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT ALSO HOUSES THE CIVIC ARTS PROGRAM. I THINK IT GOES OUTSAILING THAT BERKELEY VALUES THE ARTS. AND NOT ONLY DO THE ARTS IMPROVE THE LIVEABILITY OF OUR CITY BUT AN IMPORTANT PART OF BERKELEY'S ECONOMY. THE CIVIC ARTS PROGRAMS HELPS SUPPORT BERKELEY ART COMMUNITY THROUGH GRANT MAKING. IN 2024 WE AWARDED 111 GRANTS ACROSS FOUR CATEGORIES TOTALING$760,000. I WANT TO HIGHLIGHT THAT WE RECEIVED FUNDING LAST YEAR FROM THE NATIONAL ENDOWMENT FOR THE ARTS THAT WAS OUR SECOND YEAR OF BEING AWARDED FUNDING FROM THE N.E.A. OUR FIRST YEAR WE RECEIVED $30,000. LAST YEAR, $40,000. AND COMBINING THAT WITH THE REQUIRED LOCAL ONE-TO-ONE MATCH, WE ARE ABLE TO INVEST EVEN MORE IN BERKELEY'S ARTS COMMUNITY. IN 2024, WE WERE ABLE TO

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INVEST AN ADDITIONAL $60,000. AND THIS FISCAL YEAR, WE WILL BE INVESTING AN ADDITIONAL $80,000. IN ADDITION TO GRANT MAKING, WE ALSO SUPPORT OUR ART'S COMMUNITY BY WORKING ON REPORTS AND STUDIES. AND IN DECEMBER OF 2024, WE ENTERED INTO CONTRACT WITH A CONSULTANT WHO WILL BE CONDUCTING A NEW STUDY FOR THE ECONOMIC IMPACT OF THE ARTS IN BERKELEY. AND WE ARE CURRENTLY MID-WAY THROUGH PROCUREMENT FOR CONSULTANT TO WORK ON A PLAN FOR A RESILIENT SECTOR HERE IN BERKELEY. OKAY, SO IN ADDITION TO GRANT, WE HAVE A PUBLIC ART PROGRAM. AND IN 2024, WE COMPLETED TWO MAJOR PUBLIC ART PROJECTS. THE COMBINED BUDGETS FOR THOSE WAS ABOUT $700,000. THOSE ARE PICTURED HERE ON THE LEFT IS A SCULPTURE BY MILDRED HOWARD, INSTALLED AT THE INTERSECTION OF ADELINE AND MARTIN LUTHER KING, JR. WAY. FROM THE DEDICATION EVENT, WHICH TOOK PLACE AT JUNETEENTH LAST SUMMER. ON THE RIGHT, WAS A MURAL INSTALLATION AT UNIVERSITY AND 4TH STREET. THAT IS THE CITY OF BERKELEY'S AMTRAK STOP. SO RIGHT NOW WE'VE GOT ABOUT 18 PROJECTS THAT WE ARE ACTIVELY WORKING ON. WE HAVE 14 PROJECTS ON THE WORK PLAN. AND WE ARE ALSO CARING FOR A COLLECT OF ABOUT 100 ARTWORKS. WITH THAT, I WILL PASS IT BACK TO ELEANOR.

>> THANK YOU VERY MUCH, EVERYBODY. APPRECIATED YOU SPENDING A LITTLE TIME WITH US AND HEARING ABOUT SOME OF OUR PROGRAMS. AND LOOKING AT THE DATA FROM 2024. THE WEBSITE IF YOU CAN ACCESS THE REPORTS IS UP THERE. I INCLUDED OUR EMAIL ADDRESS. WE WELCOME

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ANYBODY TO REACH OUT WITH QUESTIONS RELATING TO CULTURAL OR COMMERCIAL INSTITUTIONS IN BERKELEY. THANK YOU.

>> MAYOR ISHII: AFTER EVERY ONE OF THE PRESENTATIONS. SO AMAZING. THANK YOU SO MUCH FOR COMING AND PRESENTING TO US. I KNOW I NEED TO TAKE PUBLIC COMMENT. I WANT TO MAKE SURE IS THERE ANYONE -- SOME FOLKS ARE MOVING UP. GO AHEAD. AND JUST TO BE CLEAR, HOW MUCH TIME DO WE HAVE?

>> COMMENTERS, IF THERE ARE A FEWER THEN 10, EACH ONE RECEIVES 2 MINUTES. CURRENTLY IT LOOKS LIKE WE HAVE A COUPLE OF IN THE ROOM AND JUST ONE HAND RAISED ON ZOOM CURRENTLY.

>> MAYOR ISHII: OKAY.

>> AS FAR AS, THANK YOU, AS FAR AS THE BUSINESS DISTRICTED VACANCY RATES, I THINK IT WOULD BE HELPFUL IF WE MOVE THE BOUNDARIES OF EVERY DISTRICT THAT IS LISTED HERE. BECAUSE IT COULD BE CONFUSED. I MEAN THERE ARE SOME THAT WOULD OVERLAP. SECOND, THANK YOU FOR THE EXCELLENT PRESENTATION. BUT SECOND, WHERE THERE IS A SIGNIFICANT INCREASE OR DECREASE IN VACANCY RATES, IT WOULD HAVE BEEN INTERESTING TO HEAR WHY THAT WAS. AND THE LAST THING I JUST WANT TO SAY IS WE'RE HEARING THIS UPBEAT PRESENTATION AT A TIME THAT WE'RE REALISTICALLY HEARING OF EVERYTHING THAT COULD POTENTIALLY BE AT RISK. SO I'M INTERESTING IN SOME OF THE POSITIVES WHAT IS REALLY AT RISK AND WHAT IS FAIRLY SECURE AT THIS TIME. THANK YOU.

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>> MAYOR ISHII: OKAY. THANK YOU. NEXT COMMENTER.

>> CANER, DOWNTOWN BERKELEY ASSOCIATION. AS I SHARED WITH SEVERAL OF YOU THE DOWNTOWNER VACANCY RATE WITH ADJUSTMENTS IS 28.2%. THAT'S DUE TO THE REMOVAL OF ABOUT A MILLION SQUARE FEET OF NON-COMMERCIAL USES, PARKING GARAGES, BERKELEY HIGH SCHOOL, ET CETERA. INCLUDING VACANCIES DUE TO PENDING DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS. WALKING THROUGH THE DOWNTOWN, IT'S A LOT MORE THAN 10%. WE HAVE 16 STALLED HOUSING PROJECTS IN THE DOWNTOWN, WITH 2900 UNITS THAT ARE NOT PENCILING RIGHT NOW. RENTS ARE DOWN 20%, AS HIGH AS 40%. CONSTRUCT RATES ARE HIGH. I'M TALKING TO DEVELOPERS. EVERY WEEK, THEY ARE ALL ON HOLD, WHICH IS A SHAME. THIS IS A BIG PROBLEM. WE HAVE 28% HOW WE CALCULATE OR WHAT WE STATE, VISUALLY WHEN YOU WALK AROUND THE DOWNTOWN WE'RE WORKING WITH OED AND COUNCILMEMBER TREGUB'S OFFICE TO IMPROVE THE SITUATION. BUT MAY NEED YOUR HELP. WE HAVE A MASSIVE MURAL PROJECT WORKING ON CENTER STREET. PAINTING CENTER STREET -- WINDOW FILM, STORE FRONT ART. POP UPS, WITH ELEANOR AND JORDAN, A ROUND TABLE, LOOKING AT WAYS TO EXPEDITE THE PROCESS. A FIELD TRIP TO SAN FRANCISCO. I HAVE A MATRIX I SHARED WITH THE LAB PROGRAMS IN SAN FRANCISCO THAT INCLUDE POP UPS TO STORE FRONT IMPROVEMENTS. WE NEED TO BEG, BORROW, AND STEEL. SOME OF THEM ARE NOT CHEAP. AND OBVIOUSLY WE'RE LIMITED BUDGETS SITUATION BUT WE NEED TO LOOK UNDER EVERY STONE. ALSO, THE HOMELESSNESS AND

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MENTAL HEALTH ISSUES, AS EVERYBODY KNOWS ARE PARAMOUNT. THERE IS A MEETING TOMORROW ABOUT ISSUES IN THE PARK THAT IMPACTS THE DOWNTOWN. AND SAFETY AMBASSADORS HAD BEEN PROPOSED AS WELL, SECURITY CAMERAS. SO THANK YOU FOR YOUR CONSIDERATION. HOPEFULLY, WE'LL BE BACK. I THANK ELEANOR AND THE TEAM FOR DOING A GREAT JOB AND FOR IGOR AND HIS STAFF.

>> MAYOR ISHII: THANK YOU.

>> EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR OF THE TELEGRAPH IMPROVEMENT DISTRICT. ALONG WITH JOHN, I WANT TO EXCISE AND ELEVATE THE NEEDS OF OUR BUSINESS DISTRICTS. THIS IS CLEARLY A MULTI-FACETTED ECONOMY IN BERKELEY AND A LOT OF DIFFERENT CONSIDERATIONS. OUR CORE DISTRICTS DO THERE ARE SERIOUS CHALLENGES AND THEY NEED TO MAINTAIN PRIORITY WITH YOU ALL AND THE WORK THAT WE'RE DOING. WE ARE FOCUSING OUR EFFORTS AROUND PLACE MAKING, BRAND DEVELOPMENT, ACTIVATION, BUSINESS SUPPORT, ATTRACTION. I THINK VINCENT SUMMARIZED IT NICELY, OUR WORK AROUND CLEAN AND SAFE INITIATIVES AND LONG-TERM PLANNING IS ABSOLUTELY SORT OF HOW WE'RE PRIORITIZING OUR WORK. AND THE TRUTH IS OUR NUMBERS ON THE GROUND TODAY FOR VACANCY ARE SLIGHTLY BETTER FROM WHEN THE DATA WAS COLLECTED. YOU KNOW, SORT OF A WASH AS FAR AS VACANCY RATES YEAR OVER YEAR. BUT YOU KNOW, NOT THAT DIFFERENT FOR WHAT JOHN WAS DESCRIBING, THE REALITY OF VACANT SPACES, PLACES IN DEVELOPMENTS BEING HELD UP FOR ANY NUMBER OF REASONS. AND IT

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SEEMS LIKE MORE THAN IT IS. BUT THE CHALLENGE IS I WOULDN'T WANT YOU TO LOOK AT THE UNDER 10% VACANCY RATE AND THINK IT'S NOT SERIOUS BECAUSE IT HAS A LARGER IMPACT THAN WHAT IT SEEMS. WE ARE ABSOLUTELY CONTENDING WITH ECONOMIC TRENDS ERODING THE VIABILITY OF RETAIL AND SUCCESS OF OUR CORE COMMERCIAL DISTRICTS. THIS IS NOT UNIQUE TO US OR TO BERKELEY AS YOU KNOW. THIS IS AN ISSUE THAT IS PLAGUING EVERYONE IN THE PLACE MANAGEMENT INDUSTRY. BUT I THINK THAT, YOU KNOW, THROUGH GIVING SERIOUS THOUGHT AND THIS WAS WHAT I WOULD ENCOURAGE YOU TO DO GOING FORWARD IS GIVE SERIOUS THOUGHT TO CHALLENGES FACED BY OUR BUSINESS DISTRICT SAID. DISTRICTS. AND PRIORITIZE OPPORTUNITIES TO INVEST IN THEM AND THE WORK THAT O.E.D. IS DOING.

>> MAYOR ISHII: THANK YOU. DO YOU WANT TO --

>> YES, I'LL WRAP UP AND SAY THANK YOU FOR THE REPORT. WE LOOK FORWARD ON WORKING TOGETHER THE REST OF THE YEAR.

>> MAYOR ISHII: THANK YOU SO MUCH. I KNOW WE HAVE ONE PERSON ONLINE. JUST TO MAKE SURE PUBLIC COMMENT IS LIMITED TO ITEMS ON THIS AGENDA ONLY. ALL RIGHT. NEXT SPEAKER IS KELLY HAMMARGREN.

>> THIS MIGHT SOUND OFF TOPIC BUT IT IS ON TOPIC. WE ARE IN A RAPIDLY CHANGING WORLD. THIS MORNING MY BOOK CLUB MET AND WE CHANGED OUR SELECTION. IT WAS AN UNEXPECTED CHOICE. AND THE SELECTION WE MADE WAS AMERICAN-MADE, WHAT HAPPENS WHEN WORK DISAPPEARS. AND WHAT MADE THAT CHANGE IS ONE OF OUR BERKELEY

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MEMBERS SAID THAT FOUR OF HER NEIGHBORS LOST THEIR JOBS THIS WEEK. THEY HAD FEDERAL JOBS. I KNOW THE ISN'T BACK AND FORTH WITH ATTENDEES. MY HOPE IS YOU AS COUNCILMEMBERS WILL PRESS OUR EXPERTS IN THE ROOM HOW THE CURRENT GUTTING OF THE FEDERAL EMPLOYEES, FEDERAL FUNDING AND GRANTS MIGHT IMPACT BERKELEY AND HOW THAT WILL IMPACT OUR ECONOMIC OUTLOOK FOR THE CITY IN THE COMING MONTHS. SO THAT'S REALLY THE THRUST OF MY COMMENT. PLEASE, PLEASE HAVE THAT DISCUSSION. BECAUSE I REALLY COULDN'T GET THE FEEL OF THAT FROM THE PRESENTATION OR THE DOCUMENTS. THANK YOU VERY MUCH.

>> MAYOR ISHII: THANK YOU. ARE THERE OTHER COMMENTS ONLINE?

>> THAT WAS OUR LAST RAISED HAND IN ZOOM.

>> MAYOR ISHII: OKAY, I'LL MOVE ONTO COUNCIL COMMENTS. LET ME -- ALL RIGHT, COUNCILMEMBER TAPLIN.

>> T. TAPLIN: THANK YOU. THANK YOU SO MUCH, THE OED TEAM. I'M ENCOURAGED TO SEE THE SALES TAX REVENUE UP ON THE RISE. I'M GLAD TO SEE HOSPITALITY DOING SO WELL IN FOOD AND BEVERAGES. I'M PROUD OF OUR ARTS INNOVATION ECOSYSTEMS. I LOOK FORWARD TO WORKING WITH YOU TO KEEP OUR COMPANIES HERE IN BERKELEY. THANK YOU.

>> MAYOR ISHII: THANK YOU. NEXT IS COUNCILMEMBER BLACKABY.

>> B. BLACKABY: FIRST A COMMENT. JUST TO THANK VINCENT AND TEAM FOR HELPING AND PITCHING IN ON THE MIGHTY NORTH SIDE AREA, THE

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BIGGEST UNDISCOVERED GEM TO BE SELFISH. THE ONE BUSINESS AREA IN DISTRICT 6, I LOVE IT VERY MUCH. AND THANK YOU, AND WE LOOK FORWARD TO WORKING TOGETHER WITH YOU ON THAT. CERTAINLY, THE INNOVATION ECHO SYSTEM IS NEAR AND DEAR TO MY HEART. WE TALKED ABOUT THAT. AND WE COMMENTED AGAIN ABOUT WE HAVE SO MANY ADVANTAGES, THE PROXIMITY TO U.C. BERKELEY, THE SMART PEOPLE COMING OUT OF THE INSTITUTION PROXIMITY TO SAN FRANCISCO AND SILICON VALLEY AND SEPARATENESS. WE HAVE UNIQUE ADVANTAGES. ANY THOUGHTS, IDEAS, RECOMMENDATIONS AS A CITY WHAT MORE COULD WE DO ENCOURAGE THE GROWTHS AND ENCOURAGE COMPANIES TO STAY HERE? AND NOT GO TO EMERYVILLE AND ALAMEDA AND SAN LEANDRO, HOW CAN WE FOSTER THAT ENVIRONMENT. WOULD LOVE THOUGHTS OR IDEAS ON THAT LINE.

>> MAYOR ISHII: GO AHEAD. YOU CAN ANSWER. THANK YOU.

>> THANK YOU FOR THAT COMMENT. WE LOOK FORWARD TO THE PARTNERSHIP WITH YOU. WE'RE EXCITED WE PASSED A LOT OF THE POLICY THAT WAS RECOMMENDED BY OUR BERKELEY START UP CLUSTER ADVISERS IN THE LAST FEW YEARS. SO IT'S A GOOD TIME TO START THINKING ABOUT WHAT IS NEXT. WE HAVE A BERKELEY START UP CLUSTER ADVISER MEETING ON MARCH 12 WHERE WE'LL ASK THE QUESTION YOU ASKED. THERE IS A COUPLE OF QUESTIONS ON CONVERSATIONS, ONE I THINK WE DISCUSSED ALREADY, OPPORTUNITIES FOR PILOTS. ESPECIALLY IN TING THINGS ALIGNED WITH CITY PRIORITIES LIKE CARBON

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EMISSIONS REDUCTION, AND CLIMATE ADAPTATION. I KNOW A LOT OF HUNGRY START UPS COMING UP WITH SOLUTIONS IN THAT SPACE THAT WOULD LOVE BERKELEY. THAT'S ONE OPPORTUNITY TO FIGURE OUT HOW THE PROCUREMENT AND LIABILITY RISKS ASSOCIATED WITH THAT. AND WHAT IS POSSIBLE ON THAT FRONT. SECONDARY IS HOW DO WE GET BUILDING STUCK IN ALIGNMENT WITH THE TYPES OF RESEARCH AND DEVELOPMENTS OR OFFICE SPACE THAT YOUNG START UPS NEED. I THINK I ALLUDED TO THIS IN MY PRESENTATION. WE HAVE A LOT OF THE LARGE FACILITIES WITH BIG FLOOR PLATES AVAILABLE TODAY LOOKING FOR TENANTS. AND WE HAVE A LOT OF SMALL COMPANIES LOOKING FOR VERY SMALL, BITE-SIZED CHUNKS THEY CAN GRADUATE INTO. WE HAVE A MISMATCH IN TERMS OF WHAT IS AVAILABLE AND WHAT IS SOUGHT AFTER. SOME OF THOSE COMPANIES FIND MORE FLEXIBILITY AND OPTIONS IN EMERYVILLE OR ALAMEDA WHERE THERE IS A CONCEPT THAT WAS PUT TOGETHER BY ONE DEVELOPER WHERE YOU CAN GET A FEW THOUSAND SQUARE FEET AND IF YOU NEED MORE YOU CAN ADD ON AS OPPOSED TO SIGNING A LEASE WHICH YOU ARE NOT READY FOR YET. I THINK WE HAVE TO THINK ABOUT THE UNIVERSITY IS DOING A LOT TO HAVE SUPPORT INNOVATION AND ENTREPRENEURSHIP AND INVESTING IN BIGGER CLIMATE LABS SPUR ENTREPRENEURSHIP AND. AND I THINK THEORETICALLY IS MORE CLEAR LIKE WE HAVE AN ENGINE OF INNOVATION RIGHT NEXT DOOR. IF THOSE THINGS ARE HAPPENING ON CAMPUS OR GRADUATE AND GO TO ALAMEDA OR EMERYVILLE, WHEN DO WE BENEFIT FROM THE INNOVATION AS

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A CITY IF WE'RE NOT DOING PILOTS AND CAPTURING THEM IN THE OFFICE AND WET LAB SPACES. THOSE ARE THINGS I THINK ARE TOP OF MIND FOR ME. I WELCOME ANY OTHER IDEAS FROM YOU AND ANY COUNCILMEMBERS OR OTHERS AT THE ADVISORY GROUP MEETING.

>> I AGREE ON THE PILOT. I'M LOOKING FORWARD TO WORK WITH YOU ON THAT. I THINK THE CITY BEING A PILOT CUSTOMER IN A PLACE WHERE IT MAKES SENSE, IT'S CONSISTENT WITH WHAT THE DEPARTMENTS WANT TO DO, MAKING SURE IF THERE IS FRICTION WE REMOVE IT. LOOK FORWARD TO FIGURING IT OUT. THANK YOU.

>> MAYOR ISHII: THANK YOU. MOVING ON. OOPS. OH, NO. I'M SO SORRY, I PRESSED THE RESET BUTTON. I THINK EITHER MAYBE IT WAS COUNCILMEMBER HUMBERT THAT WAS NEXT AND THEN BARTLETT.

>> M. HUMBERT: THANK YOU, MADAM MAYOR. I THINK IT WAS ME BUT I'M NOT SURE. OKAY. AS ALWAYS, WHEN I'VE HEARD THESE REPORTS, I WANT TO THANK STAFF AT O.E.D. FOR YOUR GREAT WORK, YOUR FOUR ROCK STARS AND EVERYONE IN THE DEPARTMENT. I THINK WE'RE KIND OF UNIQUE IN GETTING AS MUCH AS USEFUL INSIGHT AND DATA ABOUT THE LOCAL ECONOMY AS WE DO FROM YOUR REPORTS. WE'RE LUCKY TO HAVE A STRONG ECONOMY AND DEDICATED FOLKS LIKE YOU TO KEEP US ABREAST OF THEIR WORK AND THE HEALTH OF OUR BUSINESSES. ONE THING I NOTICED WAS THAT ASKING RENTS FOR STUDIO APARTMENTS INCREASED JUST A LITTLE UNDER 2% YEAR OVER YEAR, 1.7% I THINK. I HAVE TWO QUESTIONS. DOES THIS ACCOUNT FOR UNIT MIX, DOES IT ACCOUNT FOR

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THE BALANCE OF NEW VERSUS EXISTING INVENTORY ON THE MARKET?

>> I CAN ANSWER THAT. NO, IT DOESN'T. THIS IS JUST AN AVERAGE STUDIO APARTMENT. JUST TO GET A PICTURE OF THE TRENDS. WHEN YOU GET INTO UNIT MIX, THE NUMBER CHANGES QUITE A BIT AND HARD TO PRESENT IN A CLEAR FORMAT. THINK OF THIS AS IS A HIGH-LEVEL VIEW OF RENTS BUT NOT THE GRANULAR VIEW.

>> M. HUMBERT: A GLANCE, THANK YOU. THIS INCREASE IS LESS THAN INFLATION. IN YOUR VIEW, IS IT AN INDICATION MAYBE RENTS HAVE STABILIZED, THEY ARE GOING UP LESS THAN THE INFLATION RATE AND MAYBE THAT HAS TO DO WITH THE INCREASED SUPPLY OF HOUSING. THAT IS A SOFTBALL QUESTION.

>> THAT IS A GOOD ANALYSIS.

>> M. HUMBERT: THANK YOU. THAT'S ALL I HAVE. THANKS AGAIN. GREAT REPORT.

>> MAYOR ISHII: THANK YOU. I BELIEVE COUNCILMEMBER BARTLETT IS NEXT.

>> B. BARTLETT: THANK YOU, MADAM MAYOR. AND TEAM FOR GREAT WORK AS ALWAYS. AND IT'S A COUPLE OF POINTS. STARTING WITH THE GROUND FLOOR COMMERCIAL VACANCY RATE. THE DECREASE IN SOME OF THE COMMUNITIES LIKE SOUTH BERKELEY FOR INSTANCE, IT'S A PRETTY DRAMATIC INCREASE FROM 2023, 19.2% IT'S PROBABLY AN OUTLIER, THE 19.2 BECAUSE THE THREE YEARS BEFORE WERE RELATIVELY IN THE SAME BRACKET. BUT NOTING THE DECREASE, I'M WONDERING IF THE DECREASE

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IS DUE TO SORT OF OFFICE USES AND ARCHITECTURE FIRMS, THAT ARE NOT NEIGHBORHOOD SERVING GROUND FLOOR RETAIL. ANY INSIGHTS ON THAT?

>> THERE WERE A COUPLE OF THINGS WE DIDN'T NOTE. WE HAD A NUMBER OF PROPERTIES LISTED AS COMMERCIAL WHICH WERE RESIDENTIAL. SO WE LOST SOME PROPERTIES THERE IN TERMS OF VACANCY BECAUSE WE DON'T TRACK THE RESIDENTIAL VACANCY. SO THERE WERE A NUMBER OF THOSE THAT DID HAPPEN. AND SOME WE FOUND WHICH WERE KIND OF THE REVERSE, WHICH WERE OPERATING AS BUSINESSES BUT MAY NOT HAVE HAD A LICENSE. BUT AS WE WENT OUT IN THE SURVEY I NOTICED LIKE I WENTS ALONG A COUPLE OF THE AVENUES, SACRAMENTO, AND OTHER PLACES, AND I SEE A BUSINESS THERE AND LOOK IN OUR DATABASE AND FIND OUT MAYBE THEY DIDN'T HAVE A LICENSE. NOW WE'RE NOT THE ENFORCEMENT PEOPLE. BUT THAT'S SOMETHING WE NEED TO KIND OF CLEAN UP IN THE CITY OF BERKELEY IS MAKING SURE THAT WE TRACK THOSE WHO HAVE A BUSINESS THAT ARE OPERATING AND WHO HAVE A LICENSE AS WELL AS KEEPING TRACK OF THOSE CONVERSIONS FROM COMMERCIAL TO RESIDENTIAL.

>> I JUST WANTED TO INVITE EVERYBODY TO THE COMPANION DETAIL THAT CROSS, THEY HAVE A MAP THAT REPRESENTS THE BOUNDARIES OF EACH DISTRICT AND CROSSES THE SALES TAX AND THE BUSINESS MIX AND THE VACANCY RATE OVER TIME. SO YOU ARE RIGHT IN SOUTH BERKELEY A NUMBER OF PARCELS IF A LARGE FLOOR PLATE CHANGES FROM VACANT TO

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NOT THAT CAN AFFECT YOUR PERCENTAGE. WE'RE HAPPY TO DIG INTO THE DATA HOWEVER YOU WISH. TAKING A LOOK AT THE COMPANION PUBLICATION MIGHT BE HELPFUL.

>> ANECDOTALLY, MYSELF I PERCEIVE NOT NECESSARILY A TROUBLING TREND BUT MORE GROUND FLOOR PROFESSIONAL SERVICES THAN I WOULD LIKE TO SEE. WE NEED MORE WALKABILITY. WE NEED MORE NEIGHBOR SERVING RETAIL, THE CULTURAL COMPONENT OF OUR RETAIL ENVIRONMENT. AND AGAIN, THAT'S THE LARGER CONTEXT IS WE NEED TO FIGURE OUT A WAY TO INCENTIVIZE AND PROMOTE LOWERING THE RENTS ESSENTIALLY IN RETAIL SPACES SO ANYONE CAN STARTS SOMETHING UP. AND SELL CLOTHES OR COMICS OR WHATEVER. SOMETHING FOR THE COMMUNITY TO ENJOY. I KNOW WE'RE ABOUT TO LOSE OUR KEY HARBOR STORE. THE FAMILY IS OUT THE BUSINESS. IT'S GOING TO BE A BIG LOSS. SO MOVING RIGHT ALONG, THE PUBLIC --

>> I WELCOME YOU TO OPEN YOUR COMIC BOOK STORE.

>> B. BARTLETT: IF THEY LOWER THE RENT TO $600 A MONTH, I COULD DO IT. I HAVE A LOT OF COMICS, THAT WOULD BE GREAT. BUT THE PUBLIC ART PIECE IN A SIMILAR VEIN IS ANOTHER IMPORTANT ELEMENT OF CULTURAL VITALITY AND ECONOMIC GROWTH. THEY ATTRACT PEOPLE AND PEOPLE NEARBY ENGAGE IN COMMERCIAL ACTIVITY. AND SO WHILE WE ARE APPROACHING SOME BUDGET HEAD WINDS PRETTY STRONGLY THIS YEAR AND THE NEXT YEAR, YOU KNOW, THERE IS AN AVENUE OF FREE PUBLIC ART. THERE ARE PLENTY OF ARTISTS THAT WOULD LOVE TO STORE THEIR

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ARTWORK ON OUR STREETS, LARGE PIECES. I DO WANT TO ENCOURAGE YOU TO EXPLORE THAT AS A WAY TO GENERATE MORE ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT AND CULTURAL EXPRESSION. I THINK THOSE ARE MY BULK OF MY POINTS WERE COVERED. THANK YOU.

>> MAYOR ISHII: THANK YOU. I THINK COUNCILMEMBER TREGUB MIGHT BE NEXT IF THAT'S ALL RIGHT. YEAH, THANK YOU.

>> I. TREGUB: THANK YOU. I WAS INTRIGUED THAT THERE IS A PENDING APPLICATION FOR A COMIC BOOK STORE. PERHAPS I CAN GO IN WITH YOU. I'M SURE PEOPLE WOULD BUY COMICS ABOUT THE CITY COUNCIL. ANYWAY, I'M DONE. I'M GOING TO STICK TO MY DAY JOB. THANK YOU SO MUCH FOR THE PRESENTATION. THIS IS THE FIRST ONE I'VE REVIEWED ON THIS DAIS. AND JUST REALLY APPRECIATE THE ATTENTION TO DETAIL AND ALL THE HARD WORK THAT THIS HAS TAKEN. I HAVE A FEW COMMENTS AND THEN I JUST WANTED TO MAYBE I WILL ASK STAFF A SERIES OF, WELL, IT'S REALLY MORE TO INVITE STAFF TO EXPAND ON SOME THINGS. AND SO, I WILL START WITH I WAS YOU KNOW, TO KELLY'S COMMENT ABOUT THE FEDERAL GOVERNMENT RIGHT NOW. IT'S REALLY TRAGIC. AND THIS IS I WORKED FOR 12 YEARS IN THE FEDERAL GOVERNMENT. BUT WE ALL KNOW PEOPLE THAT HAVE BEEN IMPACTED BY THIS, WHETHER WE ARE OURSELVES WORKED THERE OR -- HAVE WORKED THERE OR NOT. I UNFORTUNATELY, YOU KNOW, DON'T FORESEE A LOT OF OPTIMISM ON THE MACRO ECONOMIC LEVEL, AT LEAST IN THE NEAR FUTURE. AND I'M BEARISH ON INTEREST RATES, WHICH ARE DIRECTLY RELATED TO

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VACANCIES, PARTICULARLY FOR COMMERCIAL DEVELOPMENT AND LIFE SCIENCES. SO THAT'S UNFORTUNATE, THAT'S THE REALITY IN WHICH WE NEED TO BE ABLE TO OPERATE. BUT THERE IS A LOT OF LABOR BECOMING AVAILABLE RIGHT NOW IN THESE HIGHLY TECHNICAL AREAS IN PARTICULAR, FOLKS THAT HAD A JOB IN THE FEDERAL GOVERNMENT TWO WEEKS AGO AND NOW DON'T. AND WE AS BERKELEY NEED TO BE THINKING ABOUT HOW WE CAN BE POISED TO HELP BUSINESSES THAT CAN CAPTURE THAT TALENT AND KEEP IT HERE. I WANTED YOU TO ALSO SPEND SOME TIME TALKING ABOUT -- I KNOW YOU HAVE A SMALL AND MIGHTY STAFF AND YOU CAN'T BE EVERYWHERE AT ONCE. AND I APPRECIATE THE FOCUS THAT YOU'VE HAD ON R. AND D. . IN FACT, I WANT TO ASK, I COSPONSORED AN ITEM WITH THEN MAYOR ARREGUIN LAST YEAR, AS YOU KNOW, TO UPDATE BMC SECTION 904165 TO EXEMPT THE RECEIPTS RELATED TO PHILANTHROPIC -- I WANTED TO SEE IF THE IMPACT OF THAT CHANGE OR OTHER CHANGES HAS BEEN MAKING A DIFFERENCE, A POSITIVE DIFFERENCE OR IF IT IS TOO EARLY TO TELL. I DID WANT TO BETTER UNDERSTAND HOW SMALL BUSINESSES ARE DOING THAT MAY NOT BE IN THE R. AND D. SPACE OR YOU KNOW, SO FROM THE FLOWER SHOP THAT HAS A LITTLE BOOTH IN DOWNTOWN BERKELEY, WHERE WE'VE BEEN WORKING CLOSELY WITH THE ADMINISTRATION TO HELP THEM GET CONNECTED TO POWER SO THEY CAN RUN POWER TO THE DISCUSSIONS THAT WE'VE BEEN HAVING WITH JOHN AND WITH STAFF CERTAINLY AROUND WHAT CAN BE DONE WITH THESE LARGE STORE FRONT VACANCIES TO SUBDIVIDE

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THEM INTO ALLOW FOR SMALLER BUSINESSES, INTRODUCE OTHER FLEXIBILITY, BRING IN POP UPS.

>> MAYOR ISHII: COUNCILMEMBER, SO WE DON'T LOSE THE VEIN OF YOUR QUESTIONS. YOU ARE ASKING ABOUT THE PREVIOUS ITEM AND ALSO WHAT IS BEING DONE TO SUPPORT SMALL BUSINESSES?

>> I. TREGUB: YEAH, THAT'S QUESTION NUMBER TWO. I'M ALMOST DONE. NUMBER THREE, AND I KNOW WE'VE BEEN ALREADY WORKING AND WILL CONTINUE TO WORK TO SEE WHAT CAN BE REPLICATED FROM SAN FRANCISCO VACANT TO VIBRANT PROGRAMS. I WANTED TO ASK IF YOU HAVE OBSERVED ANY INITIATIVES THAT OTHER NEIGHBORS, NOT LIMITED TO SF, MIGHT BE DOING WHERE THAT CREATES A MORE COMPETITIVE LANDSCAPE FOR BUSINESSES THEN THEY DO IN BERKELEY. ARE THERE ANY QUICK WIN TYPE POLICY SOLUTIONS THAT MAY OR MAY NOT REQUIRE COUNCIL DIRECTION IF YOU ARE ABLE TO SPEAK TO THAT. AND I THINK THOSE ARE ALL MY QUESTIONS FOR NOW. THE 28.2% STORE FRONT VACANCIES SITED BY JOHN, THAT HAS BEEN A POINT OF, YOU KNOW, OBVIOUSLY I'M CONCERNED. AND WE CAN'T BURY OR HEADS IN THE SAND. WE HAVE TO FIGURE OUT WHAT WE CAN DO AND REALLY FOCUS ON AREAS THAT ARE WITHIN OUR CONTROL. IT MAINTAINED BE MACROECONOMIC FORCES THAT KEEP INTEREST RATES HIGH. ARE THERE QUICK LOCAL SOLUTIONS THAT CAN BE IMPLEMENTED FAIRLY EASILY AND AFFORDABLY THAT WILL MAKE A BIG DIFFERENCE? THAT WILL CONTINUE TO BE MY FOCUS, THE FOCUS ON MY DISTRICT'S OFFICE AND LOOK FORWARD TO

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WORKING WITH YOU AND MY COLLEAGUES ON THOSE.

>> MAYOR ISHII:

>> WE HEARD FOUR QUESTIONS I THINK. THE FIRST ABOUT THE FEDERAL GOVERNMENT. I DO WANT TO POINT OUT THIS DASHBOARD COVERS DATA THROUGH 2024. THAT'S THE RESPONSE TO YOUR FIRST QUESTION. THE SECOND ONE, ABOUT THE HOW THE R. AND D. GRANT WAIVER PROGRAM IS GOING. AND THEN TO YOUR POINT ABOUT THE VACANCY AND THE IDEAS OF OTHER NEIGHBORS JURISDICTIONS THAT MIGHT HAVE ADOPTED NEW POLICIES AND PROCEDURES, WE VERY MUCH LOOK FORWARD TO COLLABORATING WITH YOU AND YOUR OFFICE AND THE COUNCIL AND OUR DOWNTOWN PARTNERS ON COMING UP WITH INNOVATIVE SOLUTIONS. I WOULD HOPE WE CAN DISCOVER QUICK WINS. WE'RE EXCITED TO TACKLE THE ISSUE. R. AND D. GRANT.

>> SURE. THAT YOU CAN. WE WERE EXCITED THAT PASSED UNANIMOUSLY AND YOUR COSPONSORSHIP. WE HAVE DEFINITELY HEARD ANECDOTALLY FROM A NUMBER OF COMPANIES THEY THOUGHT THAT WAS THE RIGHT THING TO DO AS I GROW HERE, THIS MAKES BERKELEY MORE COMPETITIVE. I'VE HAD CONVERSATIONS WITH A NUMBER OF PROFESSORS, POST DOCS, I CAN'T BELIEVE HOW MUCH I WOULD BE TAXED IF I GOT A GRANT, AND NOW THAT I HAVE THAT I WOULD FEEL NOR COMFORTABLE. WE DID RECEIVE APPLICATIONS AND APPROVE FOR 15 COMPANIES LAST YEAR. AND I THINK THEY SAW MY NUMBERS, THAT'S NOT ALL ONES THAT "ED" A GRANT -- EARNED A GRANT IN 2024, THE MIGHT HAVE BEEN A PRIOR

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YEAR AGAINST THE GROSS TREATMENTS. RECEIPTS, BEYOND THE ANECDOTAL, I BELIEVE IT'S VALUABLE FOR OUR OFFICE IN GOING OUT ON A ROAD SHOW AND ENCOURAGING PEOPLE TO GET A BUSINESS LICENSE. AND BE ABLE TO OFFER THE CARROT, NOT JUST A STICK. WE GOT IN THE BAKER LABS NEWSLETTER TOTIENTS A REMINDER ABOUT THE BUSINESS LICENSE REQUIREMENT AND RENEWABLE PROCESS. IF YOU GOT AN R AND D GRANT, APPLY FOR WAIVER. I SPOKE TO THE COHORT AT THE BERKELEY LAB, AGAIN WAS ABLE TO PROMOTE ALL BUSINESSES DOING BUSINESS IN BERKELEY MUST HAVE A BERKELEY BUSINESS LICENSE. IF YOU ARE GETTING AN R AND K GRANT, APPLY FOR THE WAIVER. SAME WITH SKY DECK. IT'S AN OPPORTUNITY FOR US TO PROMOTE THE BUSINESS LICENSE PROGRAM. I BELIEVE I ACTUALLY KNOW ANECDOTALLY A COUPLE OF COMPANIES SAID YOU CAME AND SPOKE, I DIDN'T KNOW I NEEDED A BUSINESS LICENSE. IT'S GIVEN US ANOTHER OPPORTUNITY TO REMIND THEM. WE DID IT BEFORE BUT NOW IT'S LIKE NEWS TO BRING IT UP AGAIN. I WOULD SAY IT'S DEFINITELY HAVING AN IMPACT. WE'VE HAD CALLS FROM BUSINESSES AND COMMENDED FOR LEADERSHIP. I PUT TOGETHER SLIDES FOR OUR ADVISER MEETING. WE GOT A LOT OF PRESS FROM THERE. A NUMBER OF PUBLICATIONS, THE SAN FRANCISCO BUSINESS TIMES, BERKELEY SIDE, THE MERCURY JOURNAL NEWS, AND ONE OR TWO OTHERS THAT ARE STATE PUBLICATIONS HAVE ALL LISTED IN THERE THAT BERKELEY MADE GREAT STRIDES BY EXEMPTING THE R. AND D. GRANT. I THINK THAT'S SOMETHING FOR OUR CITY THAT SUPPORTS START UPS TO

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GROW HERE.

>> YOU ASKED A QUESTION ABOUT MORE JUST THE GENERAL SMALL BUSINESSES. AMONG THE THINGS WE'RE SEEING WHEN I WORKED WITH THE BUSINESS COMMERCIAL DISTRICTS IS THEY ARE LOOKING TO AS I MENTIONED SOME OF THE ATTRACTION, TO MAKE SURE THEY GET MORE FOOT TRAFFIC. THEY ARE SEEING DECLINE IN SALES PER VISITOR. IF WE CAN GET PEOPLE TO STAY LONGER. SO THEY BRING UP A LOT OF DIFFERENT ISSUES. LIKE EASY PARKING. AS PEOPLE ARE LOOKING TO START A BUSINESS, THEY WANT OUR LICENSING PROCESS TO BE FASTER. IMMENSELY FASTER. GETTING AN ANSWER TO A QUESTION ABOUT YOUR BUSINESS LICENSE NEEDS TO BE FASTER AND MORE STRAIGHTFORWARD IN THE CITY OF BERKELEY. WE PUT TOGETHER AN EFFORT, LIZ WAS A CHAMPION. FOR THEM, TIME IS MONEY. EACH WEEK OR DAY THEY HAVE TO WAIT TO GET AN ANSWER TO SOMETHING LIKE GETTING THEIR FIRE PERMIT APPROVED OR GETTING THEIR BUSINESS LICENSE APPROVED, THAT'S COSTING THEM MONEY. AND SO I THINK THE BIGGEST THING WE CAN DO IN TERMS OF THE GENERIC BUSINESS ENVIRONMENTS IS TO MAKE IT FASTER. ONE THING JOHN HAS TALKED ABOUT IN TERMS OF DOWNTOWN IS AS DEVELOPERS ARE CREATING PROPERTIES WE NEED PROPERTIES THAT HAVE SHARED FACILITIES. MORE SHARED FACILITIES SO IF I'M A SMALL BUSINESS, I DON'T HAVE TO PUT IN MY OWN BATHROOM OR THIS, THAT AND THE OTHER. RATHER, I CAN HAVE A SHARED SPACE NOW THE LARGE SPACE CAN BE HOME TO MANY BUSINESSES VERSUS HAVING AN IDEAL

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CLIENT WHO CAN OCCUPY THE WHOLE SPACE. THOSE ARE SOME OF THINGS WE'RE SEEING ABOUT HOW WE CAN MAKE A MORE FRIENDLY ENVIRONMENT FOR SMALL BUSINESSES.

>> I. TREGUB: THANK YOU SO MUCH. AND LOOK FORWARD TO CONTINUING THE COLLABORATION.

>> MAYOR ISHII: THANK YOU FOR THE QUESTIONS AND FOR THE ANSWERS. WE'RE MOVING ONTO COUNCILMEMBER LUNAPARRA.

>> C. LUNAPARRA: THANK YOU SO MUCH. AND THANK YOU FOR THE THOROUGH PRESENTATION AND FOR ALL OF YOUR HARD WORK. I JUST HAVE ONE QUICK QUESTION AROUND THE CALIFORNIA GREEN BUSINESS PROGRAM. I'M CURIOUS HOW A BUSINESS CAN GET GREEN BUSINESS CERTIFIED, WHEN UTTHE PROCESS FOR THAT IS. -- WHAT THE -- AND THE REQUIREMENTS.

>> OKAY. THERE IS THE GREEN BUSINESS WEBSITE, IF YOU JUST GOOGLE, I THINK IT'S GREEN BUSINESS CA.ORG. IF YOU TYPE IN GREEN BUSINESS PROGRAM, ALAMEDA COUNTY, YOU CAN JUST LITERALLY EXPRESS INTEREST AND THE CONSULTANT THAT WORKS WITH OUR OFFICE IS A WONDERFUL WOMAN NAMED RYELIN AND LAUREN, THEY ARE ON IT AND WILL FOLLOW-UP RIGHT AWAY AND FEET WITH THE BUSINESS AND DO AN ASSESSMENT OF WATER USAGE, ENERGY USAGE, THEIR FUEL USAGE, WASTE DIVERSION. AND THERE IS A NUMBER OF THINGS HOW THEY EDUCATE EMPLOYEES AND A NUMBER OF FACTORS RELATED TO SUSTAINABILITY. BUT THEY HAVE A LONG LIST AND IT'S SECTOR SPECIFIC. SO THEY ARE NOT

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GOING TO ASK A RESTAURANT TO DO THE SAME THING AS AN OFFICE BUILDING. THEY WILL WORK WITH THE BUSINESS. THERE IS DIFFERENT TIERS, AN INNOVATOR AND BASIC TIERS. A LOT OF WAYS TO BECOME A BASIC GREEN BUSINESS OR BUSINESS THAT EXCELS AT BEING GREEN. I WOULD JUST ENCOURAGE ANYBODY WHO IS INTERESTED. THAT'S WHY WE HAVE THE LARGER NUMBER OF INTERESTED. TO PUT THEIR NAME AND INFORMATION AND START THE PROCESS. THE ONE LAST THING, THERE ARE INCENTIVES FROM EAST BAY, MUNICIPAL UTILITY DISTRICT, PG&E AND OTHER STATE INCENTIVES TO HELP WITH CHANGING TO LED LIGHTING OR LOW FLOW SHOWER OR TOILET. THE CONSULTANTS ARE KEEPING TRACK OF INCENTIVES TO OFFER COMPENSATION FOR BUSINESSES THAT WANT TO MAKE THE CAPITAL INVESTMENT.

>> C. LUNAPARRA: GREAT. THANK YOU SO MUCH.

>> YEAH.

>> MAYOR ISHII: THANK YOU. COUNCILMEMBER O'KEEFE.

>> S. O'KEEFE: SO THE WORST THING IN BERKELEY SIDE IS THAT STORY THEY POST EVERY MONTH OF ALL THE BUSINESSES THAT DIED. SO SAD, RIGHT. AND I WAS WONDERING WE'VE TALKED A LOT ABOUT VACANT STORE FRONTS BUT NOT THE ACTUAL LOSS OF THE BUSINESS THAT CREATES THE VACANT STORE FRONT. I'M WONDERING WHAT KIND OF SERVICES YOU PROVIDE OR WHAT STRATEGIES YOU HAVE TO ACTUALLY LIKE MAYBE LIKE SAVE A BUSINESS THAT'S ABOUT TO GO OUT. IF YOU CAN GIVE THEM ASSISTANCE, IF YOU PROVIDE ANYTHING LIKE THAT.

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>> THAT'S A TOUGH ONE. HERE'S ONE OF THE REASONS. IS THAT WHEN BUSINESSES ARE STRUGGLING THEY TEND TO GET QUIETER. THEY DON'T GET TO BERKELEY SIDE UNTIL THEY TURN OFF THE POWER. ONE THING WE'RE TRYING TO DO WITH OUR ENGAGEMENT WITH THE BUSINESS COMMERCIAL DISTRICT IS KEEP AN EYE ON WHAT IS HAPPENING. INVITE MORE PEOPLE TO SHOW UP. AS AN EXAMPLE TODAY I WAS IN THE ELMWOOD DISTRICT, WHICH AS A COMMERCIAL DISTRICT HAS THREE MEMBER-- THREE MEMBERS, IT CAN HAVE NINE BECAUSE EACH OF YOU CAN NOMINATE. THE MORE WE CAN GET BUSINESSES IN THE ROOMS WE CAN HEAR THE CHALLENGES AND WHERE THOSE BUSINESSES START TO TRUEING IS -- STRUGGLE. ONE THING WE DID LAST YEAR AND THE YEAR BEFORE, WE GOT THE CHAMBER TO HELP US TO DO MORE WORKSHOPS ON SOCIAL MEDIA, SOCIAL WORKSHOPS ON HOW TO DO BUSINESS WITH THE CITY OF BERKELEY AS A CONTRACTOR. AND SO, WE'RE TRYING TO GET MORE INFORMATION OUT FOR TO THE COMMUNITY SO THEY CAN TAKE ADVANTAGE OF THOSE RESOURCES AND THAT INFORMATION AND MAKE BETTER DECISIONS. ANOTHER THING WE DO IS WHEN BUSINESSES ARE COMING TO US AND TRYING TO FIGURE OUT WHAT ARE OUR LOCATION IS, WE HELP THEM GET SOME DATA ABOUT WHAT LOCATIONS MIGHT BE DESIRABLE OR LESS DESIRABLE FOR THEIR BUSINESS OPERATION. BUT YEAH, IT'S A TOUGH ONE BECAUSE MANY TIMES WHEN BUSINESSES STRUGGLE THEY STOP TALKING. UNTIL IT GETS TO THE POINT WHERE THEY ARE ABOUT TO GO UNDER, AND THEY GET LOUDER BECAUSE THEY ARE AT THE LAST END OF

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THE ROPE. AND THE OTHER LIKE GOING OUT TO THE EUCLID BUSINESS DISTRICTS, SITTING DOWN WITH THEM AND FIGURING OUT WHAT THE ISSUES ARE SO WE CAN BRING PEOPLE TO THE TABLE THAT CAN HELP. IN THEIR CASE, ONE OF THE BIGGEST ISSUES WHAT DO THEY DO WITH THEIR TRASHCAN. THE STREET DOESN'T LOOK APPEALING AND SO YOU SEE -- UC WORKED WITH THEM. OUR WASTE MANAGEMENT DIVISION WILL PICK THEM UP FROM THE BACK. IT WILL BE MORE ATTRACTIVE AND MAKE BETTER SALES HAPPEN.

>> ONE LAST PROGRAM WE MENTIONED EARLIER, PROJECT EQUITY WORKS ON HELPING A BUSINESS WITH SUCCESSION PLANNING, A BUSINESS OWNER IS GETTING TIRED, NEARING RETIREMENT, DOESN'T WANT TO PASS IT TO A FAMILY. IT CAN BE A VARIETY OF ISSUES. WHICH IS SAD, YOU ARE ABSOLUTELY RIGHT. PROJECT EQUITY HELPS THEM MAKE THE VALUE ASSESSMENT AND WHETHER IT'S AN OPPORTUNITY TO SELL THE BUSINESS TO THE EMPLOYEES THAT WORK THERE AND BECOME A WORKER COOPERATIVE. THAT IS AVAILABLE TO ALL BERKELEY BUSINESSES. IF A BUSINESS IS STRUGGLING, I WOULD ENCOURAGE THEM TO COME TO US, THE O.E.D. MAILBOX AND WE CAN PUT THEM IN TOUCH WITH PROJECT EQUITY.

>> S. O'KEEFE: THANK YOU FOR THAT. WE ALL HAVE BUSINESSES IN OUR DISTRICT WE WANT TO ADVOCATE FOR. IT WOULD BE NICE IF THERE WAS SOME KIND OF LIKE COORDINATED MESSAGING WE COULD GIVE TO OUR CONSTITUENTS OR WE'RE IN TOUCH WITH BUSINESSES, WE CAN LET THEM

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KNOW THE OFFICE OF ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT CAN DO THIS. IF WE CAN HAVE MESSAGING THAT WOULD BE GREAT AND MAYBE CONNECT MORE BUSINESSES WITH YOU GUYS BEFORE IT'S TOO LATE.

>> PLEASE MAKE ALL YOUR BUSINESS OWNERS AWARE OF THE OFFICE OF ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT NEWSLETTER, IT'S QUARTERLY. AND A WEBPAGE ON THE CITY OF BERKELEY SITE. AND THEN WE ALSO HAVE A ONE PAGER WE CAN SENTED ELECTRONICALLY TO YOU. YOU ARE WELCOME TO SHARE THAT. IT EXPLAINS THE TYPES OF SUPPORT SERVICES THAT THE CITY OF BERKELEY HAS. WE'LL MAKE SURE THAT'S AVAILABLE TO YOU.

>> MAYOR ISHII: OKAY. ANY OTHER COMMENTS? I JUST WANT TO MAKE BRIEF COMMENTS DO SAY THANK YOU ALL SO MUCH FOR YOUR WORK. I KNOW THAT YOU ARE OUT THE ON THE STREET TALKING TO BUSINESSES ALL THE TIME. AND I JUST WANT YOU TO KNOW I HEAR FROM BUSINESSES OFTEN HOW THE CHANGES YOU'VE MADE IN TERMS OF LAND USE AND MAKING IT EASIER TO NAVIGATE, HOW TO GET YOUR BUSINESS LICENSE AND THINGS LIKE THAT REALLY DOES HELP BUSINESSES. SO THANK YOU SO MUCH FOR THAT. I REALLY LOVE THAT WE'RE CREATING MORE OF A START UP CULTURE AND TRYING TO PROVIDE SPACES AND THINKING ABOUT LONGER TERM GROWTH AS COUNCILMEMBER BLACKABY BROUGHT UP AND WE HAVE CONNECTIONS TO LOANS AND GREEN BUSINESSES. I WOULD SAY LOVE TO SEE MORE BUSINESSES GET INVOLVED WITH THE GREEN BUSINESS PROGRAM. YOU KNOW, YOOI'M A BIG SUPPORTER OF THE DISCOVERED IN BERKELEY, AND USING THE HASHTAG. I WANT TO HIGHLIGHT THAT FOR

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FOLKS TO MAKE SURE YOU ARE USING THAT DISCOVERED IN BERKELEY HASHTAG SO THINGS GET SHARED. AND OF COURSE, OUR ARTS PROGRAM. JUST WANT TO SAY THANK YOU SO MUCH. I REALLY LOVE THE PIECE IN SOUTH BERKELEY. AND I'M VERY EXCITED FOR ALL THE WORK BEING DONE THERE. THANK YOU SO MUCH. AND THANK YOU EVERYONE FOR YOUR COMMENTED. I APPRECIATE IT. IS THERE A MOTION TO ADJOURN?

>> SO MOVED.

>> SECOND.

>> MAYOR ISHII: ALL RIGHT. AND UNLESS THERE'S ANY OBJECTION, I WILL HAVE THIS LISTED UNANIMOUSLY AT AYES. WE'RE ADJOURNED. THANK YOU SO MUCH. WE'LL BE BACK FOR THE COUNCIL MEETING AT 6:00. THANK YOU SO MUCH AGAIN. [ADJOURNED AT 5:27 PM]

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